



The care that you receive during your pregnancy will be a mixture of **routine checkups** and **personalized care** that works to take care of the **health** of you and your baby. Your appointments are also an opportunity to **ask questions** that will inform your choices when you **plan and prepare** for the day your baby will arrive.

Your care explained

What your prenatal care involves

Once you've absorbed the news of finding out that you are pregnant, you'll probably start to focus on the practicalities of what happens now. Should you go to see your doctor? How do you get yourself into the system of prenatal care? Who will take care of your health and the health of your unborn baby?

For most women, there will be a standard number of regular appointments to check their progress; for others there can be extra appointments if their doctor needs to keep a closer eye on them and their baby as they progress through pregnancy. You'll be given routine blood and urine tests and your blood pressure will be checked. Advice on lifestyle and well-being will also be given by your doctor. You can opt to be screened for infections and complications that could affect you or your baby, and there are ultrasounds and tests to assess your baby's health (see pp.92–103).

Prenatal appointments are a great opportunity to seek advice about the many changes you are experiencing, as well as to connect with your pregnancy, and with your baby (you'll find out how much she's growing and you might get to hear her heart beating). You can even go to

childbirth preparation classes if you want to learn more about what happens during labor and birth, and how to take care of your new baby afterward.

Your birth, your choices

Your doctor will lead your care so that you have a pregnancy that is as healthy and safe as possible, but he or she should take into account your needs and preferences. There will be some decisions about which tests you do and don't want, how and where you'd like to give birth, and whom you'd like with you when you do.

When planning your birth you might consider: Are you more comfortable with the idea of a giving birth at a hospital or birth center? How would you describe your pain threshold? Does the idea of giving birth in water appeal or fill you with dread? What about giving birth standing up, sitting in a birthing chair, or lying down? Your answers to these questions might change over the course of your pregnancy—and that's fine, too. Mapping out your wish list is a good way of honing in on specific aspects of your pregnancy, but don't let yourself get too frustrated if things don't always go according to plan. Nature sometimes has different ideas, which is all part of the adventure.